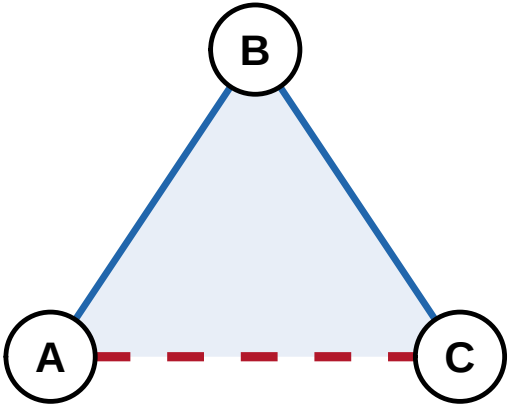
Common partner

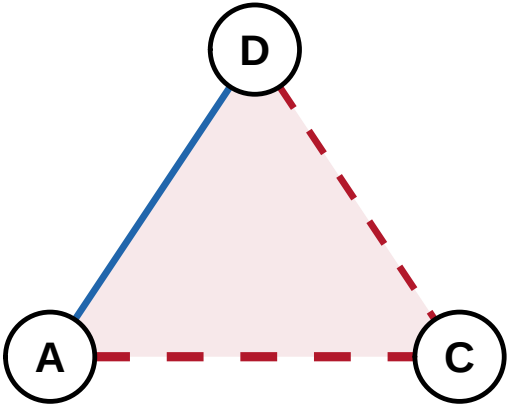


Triad (+, +, −): unbalanced

A and C are both allied with B,
so a dispute between them is inconsistent

Balance theory expects the dispute to end

Split partner



Triad (+, −, −): balanced

D is allied with A and in dispute with C,
so a dispute between A and C is consistent

Balance theory expects disputes to begin

Alliance (+) Dispute (−)